

The Cartographers of Veil

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Chapter i. The Map That Drew Itself

<!-- NOTE: mdlout has no markdown shorthand for a drop cap. The closest raw-Lout equivalent is @DropCapTwo / @DropCapThree from the bsf package, but those macros take ownership of the rest of the paragraph stream and break when the chapter body is opened separately. For now we just open with a normal paragraph; the drop cap can be inserted by hand in post if the publisher wants one. -->

It had been raining for three weeks when Aliyah first noticed that the map was changing on its own. She had pinned it to the wall of her flat on the eighth of March — a battered survey chart of the Veil basin, the kind drafted in the years when the territory still answered to two governments — and through the wet spring it had hung there unremarked, a patch of brown ink and yellowed cartouche above the kettle. It was only on the morning of the twenty-ninth that she looked up from her coffee and saw, quite plainly, that the river had moved. @FootNote { In Aliyah's defense, the Old Veil had been known to shift its course three or four times a century even before the cartographic incidents began; one can hardly blame her for assuming mundane causes at first. }

The Veil itself — the river, that is, not the basin — had spent the previous century making a slow easterly migration of perhaps half a kilometre per decade, a fact which had cost the village of Stonemoor its mill and earned the village of Briar its second one. On Aliyah's map, however, the river had since the previous evening relocated by nearly three centimetres, which, at the chart's scale of 1:50,000, worked out to something on the order of a kilometre and a half. The old course was still faintly visible, the way a pencil line survives an eraser, but the new channel was darker, more confident, and inarguably *there*.

She did what any reasonable cartographer would have done. She made a pot of fresh coffee, sat down on the floor in front of the map,